



Iguana

Iguanas are big lizards that like to eat plants. They live in warm places like Mexico and the Caribbean. A long time ago, a man named Josephus wrote about them. There are two main kinds: the green iguana, which lots of people have as pets, and the Lesser Antillean iguana, which lives in the Lesser Antilles. Scientists think there might be more kinds of green iguanas, but they are all still called green iguanas for now.

The word "iguana" comes from the Taino word "iwana." There are two kinds of iguanas, and some other lizards in the same family also have "iguana" in their names.

People like to have this animal as a pet. It has been taken to places far from where it usually lives. Now, you can find it on Ishigaki Island, in Florida, Hawaii, Singapore, Thailand, Taiwan, and many other islands where iguanas already live.

Anatomy and physiology

Iguanas are big lizards. They can be as long as a bed! They have a flap of skin under their chin and bumpy scales on their necks and tails. Some scales are big and round, and some are small and close together. Their backs have thick scales, and their tummies have thinner ones. Iguanas can be different colors. They also have a big round scale on their cheeks.

Iguanas have good eyes. They can see shapes, shadows, colors, and things moving far away. This helps them find their way in the forest and look for food. They use their eyes to talk to other iguanas.

The iguana has an eardrum called the tympanum. It is above a special part called the ear shield, right behind each eye.

Iguanas are good at hiding. They look like the places they live, so big animals can't see them.

Iguanas have a special heart with three parts. It helps them pump blood. Their muscles are light because they have special fast muscles. These muscles help iguanas move really fast for a

Iguana

Temporal range:



A green iguana (*Iguana iguana*)

Conservation status

CITES Appendix II (CITES)^[3]

Scientific classification

Domain: Eukaryota

Kingdom: Animalia

Phylum: Chordata

Class: Reptilia

Order: Squamata

Suborder: Iguania

Family: Iguanidae

Genus: Iguana

Laurenti, 1768

Type species

Iguana iguana

Linnaeus, 1758

Species

little while, like when they need to run quickly. But they can't keep moving fast for a long time.

Parietal eye

Some lizards, like iguanas, have a special pale spot on their heads. This spot helps them know if it's day or night. It talks to a part inside them called the pineal gland. There's something called parapinopsin in iguanas that helps them see light, just like in a fish called a lamprey. This helps them tell when it's day or night.

Skull morphology and diet

Iguanas like to eat plants. They munch on leaves and veggies. To eat plants, iguanas need strong jaws. Their heads are shaped to help them bite hard and chew plants well. Iguanas have big heads and bodies to help them eat. This makes their jaws strong and helps them chew tough leaves.

Iguanas have special teeth. Their teeth sit on top of their mouth bones and point up. The teeth are tiny and have little edges to help them grab and cut food.

Reproduction

Boy iguanas have two special parts called hemipenes. When they meet a girl iguana, they use one to help make babies. Girl iguanas can keep the boy's special stuff inside for a long time. This helps them have babies later, even if no boy iguanas are around.

Mating/courtship

Iguanas like to find many friends during the dry time. They do this so their babies come out when it's rainy and there's lots of food. Girl iguanas have big spaces where they make nests. Boy iguanas try to win the girls and make their own space by leaving a special smell. Boys do funny things like bobbing their heads, showing off their neck flap, and sometimes changing colors. When a girl picks a boy, he holds her by biting her shoulder. After they are together, the girl lays eggs in the nests. The eggs stay there until they hatch. Iguanas don't take care of their babies much.

Phylogeny

- Lesser Antillean iguana, *I. delicatissima*
- Green iguana, *I. iguana*

Synonyms

- *Hypsilophus* Wagler, 1830



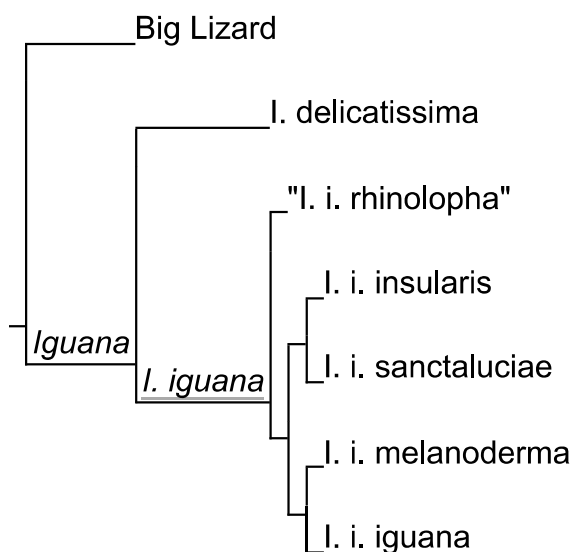
A male green iguana



Iguanas have an exclusively herbivorous diet,^[15] as illustrated above by a green iguana eating a mango in Venezuela.

Some scientists looked at lizards and snakes. They found that iguanas are in a group with snakes and some other lizards. These animals have a special mouth that can make poison. Another study said green iguanas are like mole skinks, a type of lizard. Lepidosaurs are reptiles with scales that overlap. Iguanas and tuataras use their tongues to catch food, not their mouths. This is special because only iguanas and tuataras do this. Iguanas also use their eyes to find food and wait quietly to catch it, instead of sniffing around.

A study by Breuil et al. (2020) looked at iguanas. They found that *I. delicatissima* is the oldest kind in the group. The species are sorted into smaller groups called subspecies.



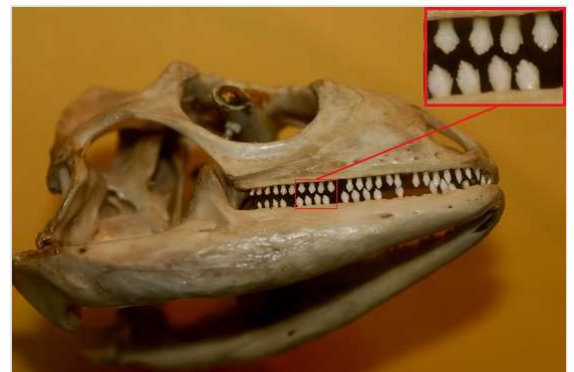
There are different kinds of green iguanas. Some are like cousins. They live in different places. One kind lives in Saint Vincent and Grenada. Another kind lives in Saint Lucia. Some live in the northern Lesser Antilles and maybe in Venezuela, the Virgin Islands, and Puerto Rico. The last kind lives in mainland South America. They are all part of the same big iguana family!

Extant species

There are two kinds of iguanas that people know about today.

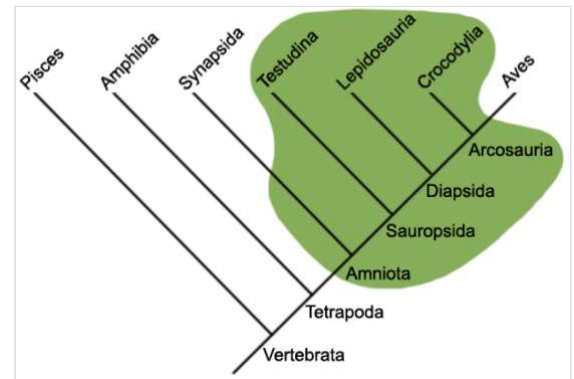


Albino Iguana - Bred to be kept as a pet



Green iguana skull and teeth: The teeth of the green iguana sit on the surface of the jawbone, known as acrodontal placement.^[18]

Image	Scientific name	Common name	Distribution
	<i>Iguana delicatissima</i>	Lesser Antillean iguana	The Lesser Antilles on Saint Barth, Anguilla, Sint Eustatius, Guadeloupe, Dominica, and Martinique
	<i>Iguana iguana</i>	Green iguana	Most of South America, from Colombia east to French Guiana and south to northern Argentina. Also introduced to parts of the Caribbean. If other species formerly considered conspecific are included, ranges north to southern Mexico and the southern Caribbean; specifically Grenada, Aruba, Curaçao, Trinidad and Tobago, St. Lucia, St. Vincent, and Utila.



Simple phylogeny with Reptilia highlighted in green: Iguanians are within Lepidosauria.

Subspecies

There are three special kinds of green iguanas that live in the Caribbean.

Image	Subspecies	Common name	Distribution
	<i>I. i. insularis</i> ^[26]	Grenadines horned iguana	St. Vincent and the Grenadines and Grenada
	<i>Iguana iguana melanoderma</i> ^[6]	Saban black iguana	Saba, Montserrat, and formerly Redonda, but also possibly coastal Venezuela, the Virgin Islands, and Puerto Rico (at least parts of this range may derive from (pre)historic introductions).
	<i>I. i. sanctaluciae</i> ^[26]	Saint Lucia horned iguana	St. Lucia

There are iguanas with horns. Some people think they are different kinds, but others say they are the same as regular iguanas. There are two special iguanas from islands, but they might not be that different from each other. Some studies say these iguanas are different, but not everyone agrees. On one island, the iguanas might be a new kind we don't know about yet.

As food

Iguanas are sometimes eaten in Mexico and Central America. People also eat iguanas in some places in the United States and Puerto Rico. In some parts of Latin America, like Nicaragua and Colombia, people eat iguana eggs too.

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